

Catan: Seafarers Expansion Rules

Seed Fixture - Synthetic Reference Document

This document is a synthetic seed fixture for the Tabletop Oracle project. It contains original text summarising game mechanics for use in automated testing of the document ingestion pipeline, knowledge graph construction, and AI query validation. This is not a copy of any copyrighted rulebook.

Overview

Catan: Seafarers is an expansion for the Catan base game, designed by Klaus Teuber and first published in 1997. It extends the game to include sea travel, ship building, and exploration of new islands. The expansion requires the Catan base game to play and supports 3 to 4 players (expandable to 5-6 with an additional extension). Seafarers introduces ships, the pirate, gold river hexes, and multiple island scenarios with varied victory point targets.

New Components

Seafarers adds 60 ships (15 per colour), 1 pirate pawn, 6 frame pieces for extended sea borders, additional terrain hexes including gold river hexes, additional harbour tokens, and scenario booklets. Ships use the same colour pieces as roads and share the 15-piece limit with roads -- a player has 15 total pieces that can be roads or ships.

Ships

Ships are the maritime equivalent of roads. A ship costs 1 wool and 1 lumber to build. Ships are placed on edges between two sea hexes, or between a sea hex and a land hex (coastal edges). Ships connect to settlements, cities, and other ships to form shipping routes. A shipping route is a continuous chain of ships connecting settlements or cities. Ships and roads may connect at a settlement or city, allowing a player to extend their network from land to sea and back. Open ships (the last ship in a shipping route that does not connect to a second settlement or city at its far end) may be moved: the player removes the ship and places it at any other legal coastal or sea edge connected to their network. A ship may not be moved on the same turn it was built. Closed shipping routes (connecting two settlements/cities at both ends) cannot have their ships moved.

The Pirate

The pirate is the sea counterpart to the robber. When a 7 is rolled, the active player may choose to move either the robber or the pirate (but not both). The pirate is placed on any sea hex. While the pirate occupies a sea hex, no ships may be built on edges adjacent to that hex, and existing ships on those edges cannot be moved. After placing the pirate, the player may steal 1 random resource card from any player who has a ship on an edge adjacent to the pirate's hex. Knight cards may also be used to move the pirate instead of the robber.

Gold River Hexes

Gold river hexes are a new terrain type that produce gold. When a gold river hex's number is rolled, each player with a settlement adjacent to it chooses any 1 resource card from the bank. Players with a city adjacent to a gold river hex choose any 2 resource cards. Gold river hexes are powerful because they provide flexibility -- the player decides which resource they need most at that moment.

Longest Road with Ships

In Seafarers, the Longest Road calculation includes both roads and shipping routes. A player's longest trade route is the longest continuous path of roads and ships, counting each segment once. Roads and ships connect at settlements or cities -- a road cannot directly connect to a ship without an intervening building. The Longest Road card is awarded to the player with the longest combined trade route of at least 5 segments.

Island Scenarios

Seafarers includes multiple scenarios with different island configurations and victory conditions. Heading to New Shores: players start on a main island and must sail to settle smaller islands. Building a settlement on a new island earns a bonus victory point. The Four Islands: four separate island groups are arranged with sea between them. Players must settle on at least two different islands. Through the Desert: a large desert separates two fertile regions, forcing players to build around it or sail between coastal areas. The Fog Island: some hexes start face-down and are revealed only when a player builds a settlement or ship adjacent to them, adding an exploration element. Each scenario specifies the number of victory points needed to win (typically 12 to 14, higher than the base game's 10).

Setup Changes

Seafarers modifies the standard Catan setup. The frame is extended with additional sea border pieces to create a larger play area. Terrain hexes, sea hexes, and harbour tokens are arranged according to the chosen scenario's map. Players may start with settlements on the main island (scenario-dependent) and must build ships to reach other islands. The robber starts on the desert as usual, and the pirate starts off the board (placed only when first activated by a 7 roll or knight card).

Building Costs Summary

The following building costs apply in Seafarers (unchanged from base game except for the addition of ships). Road: 1 brick + 1 lumber. Ship: 1 wool + 1 lumber. Settlement: 1 brick + 1 lumber + 1 wool + 1 grain. City upgrade: 2 grain + 3 ore. Development card: 1 wool + 1 grain + 1 ore. Note that ships and roads share a pool of 15 pieces per player.

Victory Conditions

Victory conditions vary by scenario but follow the same principle as the base game: reach the target number of victory points. Points are earned from settlements (1 VP each), cities (2 VP each), Longest Road / longest trade route (2 VP), Largest Army (2 VP), victory point development cards (1 VP each), and scenario-specific bonuses (e.g., 1 VP for settling on a new island in Heading to New Shores). The target is typically 12 to 14 VP depending on the scenario.